Philosophy Lectures · outside the curriculum; it falls within History of Philosophy (2nd year) and Philosophy (1st year) · If God is dead, what is left? · Class 2 of 8 · With Javier

How the chair was emptied

Class video: https://youtu.be/unoQ5TY11e8
This sheet online: https://gincollab.github.io/aula/en/conf-filosofia/t01-c2/
The code leads to the video.

In a nutshell

It is a **lecture, not a class**: about seventeen minutes for listening and thinking, with no exercises, no countdowns and no questions to take home. Javier speaks from the school assembly hall. It is the second in a series of eight, "If God is dead, what is left?", and it stands on its own.

The message, what listeners take away for their own lives: *no one can think for you. Doubt what you are handed ready-made and give yourself the law, one that holds for everyone and tramples on no one. It is a burden, and it is your dignity.* The whole lecture is at the service of that idea; the authors are there to think with today, not to pile up facts.

It is Javier's reading, and he says so. At the start he tells us what he thinks, "which isn't dogma": the chair wasn't emptied by its enemies, it was emptied by those who wanted to save it. At the end he also gives the opposite reading (that deep down they no longer believed and wrote carefully for fear of censorship), and says that he believes they really did want to save it.

The journey. Lecture 1 left three questions that, for about a thousand years, in Europe, God answered: what is true, what is right and what is wrong, and what we live for. This lecture takes them up, and their answers change before the viewer's eyes:

- **What are you sure of?** Javier starts with himself: he is a character made with artificial intelligence, and today any photo, video or voice can be fabricated. The question is what for: to help (to teach, to give a voice back to someone who lost it to an illness) or to deceive (the voice of a relative asking you for money, the fake news story that wants you to get angry and share it). And it has never been so comfortable to let someone else think for you. Then come the map of the series, lecture 1 in a sentence and today's objective.

- **Doubting everything.** The winter of 1619: at twenty-three, Descartes is a soldier in a war of religion in which each side calls on God. He decides to tear down everything he believes and to look for something anyone can check, whichever side they are on. He doubts the senses and dreams (with Zhuangzi's butterfly, almost two thousand years earlier) and imagines an evil demon.
- **The rock.** "I think, therefore I am": the rock is inside. God is still in the chair, but proved starting from the self, and the first question passes to reason. The first rule of his method: accept nothing without evidence, without haste or prejudice, neither because someone else says so nor because lots of people say so.
- **Kant's glasses.** The Copernican turn: things reach us adjusted to our way of knowing. Space, time and cause are not drawn from experience: they are a priori, glasses you can't take off. Reason has a limit, and Kant "had to deny knowledge in order to make room for faith": God leaves the question of knowledge and stays in the third question as hope.
- **The law you give yourself.** Heteronomy; obeying is comfortable ("so long as I can pay"), and that list, today: an AI, a video, an app. The motto *sapere aude*. Autonomy, which is not whim; the categorical imperative and the false promise: whoever makes it makes an exception of themselves. The second question passes to "the law I give myself".
- **What has no price.** Humanity, "never simply as a means"; price and dignity; autonomy, the ground of dignity. And **other people exist**: giving yourself the law isn't doing whatever you feel like, as if you lived alone; a law you give yourself to trample on someone else isn't autonomy, it's abuse. Was everyone allowed to be their own master? Kant declares woman "civilly immature" (1798), Wollstonecraft (1792) wants women to have "power over themselves", and even the wisest get things wrong: thinking for yourself also means seeing where a great philosopher goes wrong.
- **What is left?** The starry heavens and the moral law: the north that the madman of lecture 1 was looking for is also within. God has only the third answer left, the one Nietzsche will find empty. Reason sits down in the chair, "what Descartes called the natural light. Yours": no one can tell you from outside what is true or what is right, "not even me".

Objective. By the end, students will know how, according to a reading that presents itself as such, Descartes and Kant, who did not want to drive God out, sat reason down in his chair: first to know what is true (doubting everything until finding something certain, without haste or prejudice) and then to know what we ought to do (the law we give ourselves, which holds for everyone, and the dignity of what has no price). And what that means for them: that no one can think for them.

What it doesn't do. It gives no verdict on God: Javier says expressly that the task of thinking for yourself is for believers and non-believers alike, and those who believe have their own lecture, number 7. There is no homework: the full texts are on the student worksheet, for anyone who wants to read them.

For readers outside Spain: the Bachillerato is the last two years of secondary school (ages 16–18); Philosophy is compulsory in the first year for every track, and History of Philosophy in the second. On this sheet, "1st year" and "2nd year" (1.º and 2.º in Spanish) are those two years. Royal Decree 243/2022 sets the minimum curriculum of the Bachillerato for the whole of Spain; the Philosophy Lectures are one of the channel's series and sit outside it. The video is in Spanish, with English subtitles. On this sheet the quotations are given in English from their originals (French, Latin, German and Chinese), following the

standard translations where there is one; Wollstonecraft's are her own words. A *comentario de texto*, or text commentary, is the classic Spanish classroom exercise of explaining a philosophical passage in writing.

Where it falls in the curriculum

The Lectures sit outside the curriculum: they neither follow the syllabus nor replace it. But this one falls squarely within it (Spain's Royal Decree 243/2022, annex II; the decree's wording, in our translation of the official Spanish text):

Subject and block	What the decree says	What the lecture adds
History of Philosophy, 2nd year, block B	"Rationalism and empiricism: René Descartes and David Hume" and "The problem of the relationship between faith and reason".	Methodical doubt (the senses, dreams, the evil demon), the *cogito*, God proved from the self and the first rule of the method, with its reason why: something anyone can check in a war of religion
History of Philosophy, 2nd year, block C	"The critical philosophy of Immanuel Kant and the problem of metaphysics as knowledge" and "Ethics of happiness and ethics of duty".	The Copernican turn, the a priori, the limits of reason and faith; heteronomy and autonomy, the categorical imperative (the universal law and humanity as an end), price and dignity
History of Philosophy, 2nd year, block C	"The Enlightenment project: the power and the limits of reason. The Rights of Man. The first wave of feminism: Mary Wollstonecraft and Olympe de Gouges".	Immaturity and *sapere aude* (1784) set against the "civil immaturity" of women (1798), and Wollstonecraft's answer
Philosophy, 1st year	"The question of virtual realities", "The philosophical problem of the existence of God", the ethics of duty and "Human rights: their genesis, legitimacy and present-day validity".	The evil demon today (what is fabricated with AI), faith that is not knowledge, duty, dignity without a price and the limit of one's own freedom: other people

How the lecture is built

Video chapters

Minute	Chapter
0:00	What are you sure of?
2:47	Doubting everything
4:55	The rock
6:33	Kant's glasses
8:32	The law you give yourself
11:27	What has no price
14:29	What is left?

- **Seven chapters**, each with something that moves: the three columns of the "what for?" of what is fabricated, the map of the series, the house of beliefs torn down and the rock beneath the sand, the butterfly that flies out of the dream, the evil demon, the chain that changes order (God → the world → man, and I → God → the world), the observer turning among motionless stars and his glasses, the puppet hanging from urges, fear and what everyone else does, the crowd whose promises go out, the word "simply" crossed out and given back, the price tag that won't stick to a person, the row of people in which "you" are not alone, the compass that stops spinning and the chair with its candle.
- **The visual thread is three cards**, the questions of lecture 1, whose answers change: "what is true", from God to reason; "what is right", from God to the law I give myself; "what we live for", God, as hope.
- **Nine pauses**, of 3.8 to 4.5 seconds, without warning and without a countdown:
- And you, which uses seem fine to you, and which don't? And of everything you've seen today, on any screen, what are you sure of?
- How do you know you're not dreaming right now?
- How many of the things you share have you checked yourself?
- When you do what is right, why do you do it?
- Could you want everyone to do what you do?
- Have you ever been treated as if you had a price?
- Can you be free on the inside, if you're not allowed to be free on the outside?
- The series' question: if God is dead, what is left?
- And you, who dictates the law to you?
- **Each quotation, with its work** on screen. Javier reads them; the authors are given no voice. The translations into Spanish are our own and literal, checked against the original (Adam-Tannery for

Descartes, the Akademie-Ausgabe for Kant, the eKGWB for Nietzsche). What Javier says in his own words (price and dignity) goes on the board in chalk, not as a quotation.

Using it in class, if you wish

The lecture sets no task. If teachers want to use it, here are three ways, from least to most time:

- **Reading aloud.** The first two paragraphs of "What Is Enlightenment?" (1784) take three minutes to read and are on the student worksheet. After the lecture, students recognise the "so long as I can pay" and can make their own list for today.
- **With 1st-year students, fifteen minutes of dialogue.** Three questions, with no single answer:
- Which uses of a fabricated voice or face seem fine to you, and which don't? What makes the difference: the tool, what it is for, or being told the truth?
- What is the difference between making use of someone and treating them "simply" as a means? Find an example of each.
- If each of us gives ourselves our own law, what stops someone from giving themselves a law to trample on another? What does Kant answer, and what would you answer?
- **With 2nd-year students, a text commentary.** The passage on humanity and the one on price and dignity from the *Groundwork* (AA IV 429 and 434–436), in García Morente's Spanish translation (1921, public domain) or, in English, in T. K. Abbott's (public domain, at Project Gutenberg). The lecture serves as an introduction and does not do the commentary for them: it leaves out the kingdom of ends and the third formula of the imperative.

Misreadings the lecture takes apart

What is often said	What the text says
Autonomy is doing what you want	It is giving yourself a law that holds for everyone. Whim is heteronomy too: it is dictated by urges, fear or what everyone else does. And it never allows you to treat another person as a thing
Kant: "never use anyone as a means"	"Never **simply** as a means" (*niemals bloß als Mittel*, AA IV 429). Without that word we couldn't even catch a bus
A priori means "innate", or "before" experience in time	It means not depending on experience. Kant writes that all knowledge begins with experience, but not all of it arises from experience (B 1)

What is often said	What the text says
The imperative is the golden rule, "do not do to others what you would not want done to you"	Kant calls it "trivial" and distinguishes it from his principle (AA IV 430, note)
The false promise is wrong because, if everyone made it, things would turn out badly	If everyone made it, the promise itself would disappear. And the liar can only do it if others don't: he makes an exception of himself (AA IV 422 and 424)
Sapere aude is Kant's	It is Horace's (*Epistles* I.2); Kant makes it the motto of the Enlightenment (AA VIII 35)
Kant was an atheist, or his ethics does without God	Morality doesn't need God for us to know our duty, but the hope that those who act well will be happy calls for a God. Kant said he believed, though without knowing: "I had to deny knowledge in order to make room for faith"
"I think, therefore I am" is in the *Meditations*	It is in the *Discourse on Method* (1637); the *Meditations* (1641) say "I am, I exist"
Descartes's doubt, the demon and the *cogito* came in the stove-heated room (1619)	In 1619 he decides to tear down his opinions and, by his own account, sets himself the rules of the method; the meditations come from his retreat in Holland, some ten years later

Going further: what the lecture doesn't say aloud

The lecture deliberately leaves out what did not serve its message. For anyone who wants more:

- **Descartes holds back *The World*** (letter to Mersenne, November 1633): on learning that Galileo has been condemned, he decides not to publish the book in which the Earth moved. Prudence, not proof that he didn't believe: he dedicates the *Meditations* to the theologians of the Sorbonne.
- **Pascal and the "flick of the finger".** "I cannot forgive Descartes: in all his philosophy he would have liked to be able to do without God; but he could not help making him give a flick of the finger to set the world in motion." It is not in Pascal's own hand: his niece, Marguerite Périer, reports it (Brunschvicg 77, Lafuma 1001).
- **Augustine**, twelve centuries before Descartes: "if I am mistaken, I exist" (*The City of God*, XI 26).

- **Kant's three questions** (*Critique of Pure Reason*, A 805/B 833): What can I know? What ought I to do? What may I hope? The lecture uses those of lecture 1, which are similar; the fourth, "What is the human being?", is from the *Logic* (1800).
- **Russell** called Kant's turn a "Ptolemaic counter-revolution" (*Human Knowledge*, 1948): he put man back at the centre.
- **The glasses** are the image of the poet Heinrich von Kleist, who in his letter of 22/03/1801 to Wilhelmine von Zenge speaks of "green glasses instead of eyes". Reading Kant threw him into a crisis.
- **Heine** mocked Kant (1834/1835): after killing God in the *Critique of Pure Reason*, he brings him back to life out of pity for his servant Lampe. It is the reading opposite to Javier's, like Nietzsche's: since Descartes, modern philosophy is "covertly or overtly, anti-Christian" (*Beyond Good and Evil*, § 54, 1886).
- **Kant and the king** (1794): Frederick William II forbids him to write about religion, and Kant promises to keep silent "as Your Majesty's most faithful subject", a formula that held only while that king lived (*The Conflict of the Faculties*, 1798, preface).
- **Kant and women**, beyond 1798: in 1764 he mocks learned women (Madame Dacier, the Marquise du Châtelet) and in 1797 he excludes "all women" from the vote (*The Metaphysics of Morals*, § 46).

Open resources

- Descartes, *Discourse on Method* (1637), the 1st edition, scanned (Smithsonian Libraries, archive.org, public domain): https://archive.org/details/discoursdelamet00desca
- Descartes, *Discourse on Method*, tr. John Veitch (Project Gutenberg): https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/59; and *Meditations on First Philosophy*, tr. John Veitch (Wikisource): https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Meditations_on_First_Philosophy
- Zhuangzi, the Chinese text with an English translation (Chinese Text Project): https://ctext.org/zhuangzi/adjustment-of-controversies
- Kant, the complete works in German (Akademie-Ausgabe, korpora.org): https://korpora.org/kant/
- Kant, *Groundwork* ("Fundamental Principles of the Metaphysic of Morals"), tr. T. K. Abbott (Project Gutenberg): https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/5682
- Kant, "What Is Enlightenment?", in German (Wikisource): https://de.wikisource.org/wiki/Beantwortung_der_Frage:_Was_ist_Aufkl%C3%A4rung%3F
- Wollstonecraft, *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (Project Gutenberg): https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/3420
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy: "Descartes", https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/descartes/; "Kant's Moral Philosophy", https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/kant-moral/; "Kant's Philosophy of Religion", https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/kant-religion/; "Mary Wollstonecraft", https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/wollstonecraft/; "Zhuangzi", https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/zhuangzi/

Sources

- Descartes, *Discours de la méthode*, 1637, II, III and IV (AT VI 11, 18, 29 and 32); *Meditationes*, 1641, I–II (AT VII 19, 22 and 25); letter to Mersenne, November 1633 (AT I 270–272).
- Zhuangzi, ch. 2 ("Qiwu lun"), the butterfly dream.
- Kant, *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*, 1781 and 1787 (B 1, B XVI, B XXX, A 805/B 833); "Was ist Aufklärung?", 1784 (AA VIII 35); *Grundlegung*, 1785 (AA IV 414–436); *Kritik der praktischen Vernunft*, 1788 (AA V 161); *Anthropologie*, 1798, § 48 (AA VII 209).
- Wollstonecraft, *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman*, 1792, ch. IV. Nietzsche, *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft*, 1882, § 125 (eKGWB).
- The checks, quotation by quotation, with the original and the translation (in Spanish): `clases/conf-filosofia-t01-c2/verificacion-diseno.md`, `verificacion-guion.md`, `verificacion-borrador-3.md` and `revision-guion-4.md`.

About this lecture

Javier is an illustrated character and his voice is synthetic, and he says so himself at the start. The script is written by an AI (Claude, by Anthropic) and reviewed by a person. Every fact and every quotation has been checked in the original source or in two sources. This English version was translated by the same AI. This sheet is licensed under CC BY 4.0.

How to cite this sheet

GinCol Lab (2026). *How the chair was emptied*. GinCol Lab teacher sheet: Philosophy Lectures · outside the curriculum; it falls within History of Philosophy (2nd year) and Philosophy (1st year) · If God is dead, what is left? · Class 2 of 8. https://gincollab.github.io/aula/en/conf-filosofia/t01-c2/. CC BY 4.0.